An Afternoon at a Time

An ordered plan for getting Mom's income, accounts, property and paperwork written down, with a line for who does each part and by when.

The goal: Mom's income, accounts, insurance, property, debts and regular expenses are written down in one place, and the paperwork behind them can be found without a search.

Take one line per sitting if that's the pace that suits Mom. Put a name beside each action. “By when” can be a month or a season; nothing on this page has a deadline.

ACTION	WHO	BY WHEN	DONE
1. Ask Mom whether she's willing to do this together, what she's comfortable sharing, and who else she wants involved. Note who looks after her bills and accounts now.			
2. List every source of income: Social Security, any pension, anything else that comes in regularly. Write each amount as its paperwork shows it.			
3. List her checking and savings accounts and any CDs, with the bank or credit union each one is with.			
4. List any investment, brokerage and retirement accounts, and the company that holds each.			
5. List her insurance: life insurance, annuities, long-term care insurance and her health coverage.			
6. List what she owns: her home, any other real estate, vehicles, other significant property and any business interest.			
7. List her debts and her ordinary monthly expenses, taken from the bills and statements.			
8. Beside each account, policy and property, write whose name it's in and who is named as beneficiary, as the paperwork shows. Where it doesn't say, write “to ask.” Change nothing.			
9. Gather the paperwork behind the list: recent account statements, insurance policies, deeds and property records, recent tax returns.			
10. Choose one secure place for it with Mom, and write down who she wants to know where it is.			

ACTION	WHO	BY WHEN	DONE
11. Put it on one dated page: what you know, where it's kept, what's missing, and the questions you want to ask a professional. Write the amounts as you found them; this page doesn't need a total.			

You're done when

Mom's income, accounts, insurance, property, debts and regular expenses are written down in one place, the paperwork behind them is together where the family can find it quickly, and anything still missing is listed with a name beside it. What comes after that, the review of the inventory and any decision about accounts, property or paying for care, isn't on this list, because it isn't the family's to do alone.

If an afternoon doesn't go to plan

- Don't fill a gap by guessing. “Don't know yet” is a finished line.
- If Mom would rather stop, stop. The list will keep.
- If a question about ownership or a beneficiary comes up, write it down for a professional and carry on with the list.

What this plan doesn't do

It organizes your family's own financial information. It doesn't determine Medicaid eligibility, recommend a legal or financial strategy, or stand in for the professional review it prepares you for. Rules vary by state; bring those questions to your Medicaid planner or the appropriate licensed professional. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You and Mom have worked down the list, and the page has a date on it. The planning interview goes on from there: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

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